

GOLDEN HOURS
A woman in Modhera village cleaning a solar panel on her rooftop

NANDAN DAVE

INDIA TODAY RPG Happiness Quest

Sunshine Village

SURYAGRAM PROJECT
FOUNDED: 2019-20
Gujarat

Happiness delivery: Modhera in Gujarat has become a net-renewable energy generator, setting an extraordinary example for sustainable living

By **JUMANA SHAH**

Ajaysinh Solanki, a 21-year-old mechanical engineer, is hoping to welcome the summer this year with an air conditioner, a 'luxury' that until now hardly anyone in his village could afford. On the terrace of his modest one-storey house—Solanki's is a joint family of 20—in Modhera village in Gujarat's Mehsana district are items that are common for a typical rural household in India: pickles and spices laid out under the sun, a clothesline, an occasional straw mat. Among these, however, are also four shiny solar panels of 1 KW each that the members of the house take turns to clean. Nobody is complaining, though. Installed just about a year ago—with no hefty down-payment—these solar panels are the reason behind an extra Rs 500 Solanki is now able to save every month because of the significant reduction in his monthly electricity bill. He hopes that the money will help with his sisters' education. Others in Modhera have similar stories to share. For some households, in fact, electricity is now entirely free of cost.

There are roughly 1,700 houses in Modhera, and 1,350 of them now have rooftop photovoltaic (RTPV) systems. A year ago, the Gujarat government completed installing RTPV systems in the village under the Suryagram Project. The programme, carried out at a cost of Rs 80.66 crore, has been split between the Centre and the state government. Each house is linked to the central electricity grid, and power expenses for most households have reduced by 40 to 100 per cent.